

Rating Area 6: South Central Pennsylvania

Counties: Adams, Berks, Cumberland, Dauphin, Franklin, Fulton, Lancaster, Lebanon, Perry, York **Report Date:** May 6, 2026

1. Market Summary

Rating Area 6 is the political and geographic heart of Pennsylvania's health insurance market. In May 2026, it is facing the most publicized "affordability shock" in the Commonwealth. The region is served by a high number of carriers—including **Capital Blue Cross**, **Highmark**, **Geisinger**, and **UPMC**—but the presence of multiple choices has not shielded residents from the double-digit rate hikes approved for 2026.

2. The 2026 "Price of Coverage"

The rate increases in the Harrisburg-York-Lancaster corridor have been among the steepest in the state, largely due to high utilization of specialized medical services in the Capital region.

- **Keystone Health Plan Central (Capital BC):** Approved for a **22.4% increase**.
- **Highmark Inc. (BCBS):** Approved for a **17.7% increase**.
- **UPMC Health Options:** Approved for a **20.2% increase**.
- **Geisinger Health Plan:** Approved for an **11.6% increase**.

The "York County Crisis"

York County has become the state's primary case study for the "Subsidy Cliff."

- **The Reality:** A 60-year-old couple in York earning \$75,000 (just over the 400% FPL limit) saw their monthly premium for a Silver plan move from **\$586/month in 2025** to **\$2,916/month in 2026**. Their total annual cost for insurance now exceeds **\$35,000**, consuming nearly 47% of their pre-tax household income.

3. Enrollment & Consumer Behavior

Rating Area 6 is seeing a massive shift in how people utilize the Pennie marketplace.

- **The Lancaster "Opt-Out":** In Lancaster and Berks counties, there is a notable trend of small business owners and farmers dropping traditional marketplace coverage in favor of "Health Care Sharing Ministries" or unregulated "short-term" plans. While these are cheaper, they do not provide the consumer protections or comprehensive coverage mandated by the ACA.
- **Silver to Bronze Migration:** Approximately **38% of renewing enrollees** in Harrisburg and Cumberland County downgraded their plan level to Bronze during the last open enrollment to keep their monthly premiums below \$500.

4. Provider Network & Access Alerts

- **The "Health System Tug-of-War":** With major systems like **Penn State Health**, **WellSpan**, and **UPMC Central PA** all operating in this area, network "tiering" has become aggressive. Some 2026 Capital Blue Cross plans have placed Penn State Health providers in a "Preferred" tier while placing UPMC facilities in a "Standard" tier with higher out-of-pocket costs.
- **Specialty Care Wait Times:** Due to the 2026 "enrollment churn," many residents are switching plans and providers simultaneously. In Dauphin County, wait times for new-patient appointments in cardiology and endocrinology have spiked to **14 weeks**.

5. Direct Guidance for Area 6 Residents

- **Legislative Assistance:** Residents in Area 6 are encouraged to contact their State Representatives regarding **Senate Bill 1071**. This proposed legislation aims to create a state-funded subsidy to bridge the gap left by the expired federal credits for those earning between 400% and 600% FPL.
- **Lancaster/Berks Comparison:** If you live in Lancaster or Reading, compare Highmark and Capital Blue Cross side-by-side. In 2026, Highmark's PPO options are often pricing out slightly lower for middle-aged adults, whereas Capital Blue Cross offers better "integrated" rates for those using WellSpan facilities.
- **The "Pennie" Easy Enrollment:** If you are filing taxes in Harrisburg or York this month, be sure to use the "Easy Enrollment" check-box. State navigators are prioritizing Area 6 for outreach due to the high volume of "subsidy cliff" victims in this region.